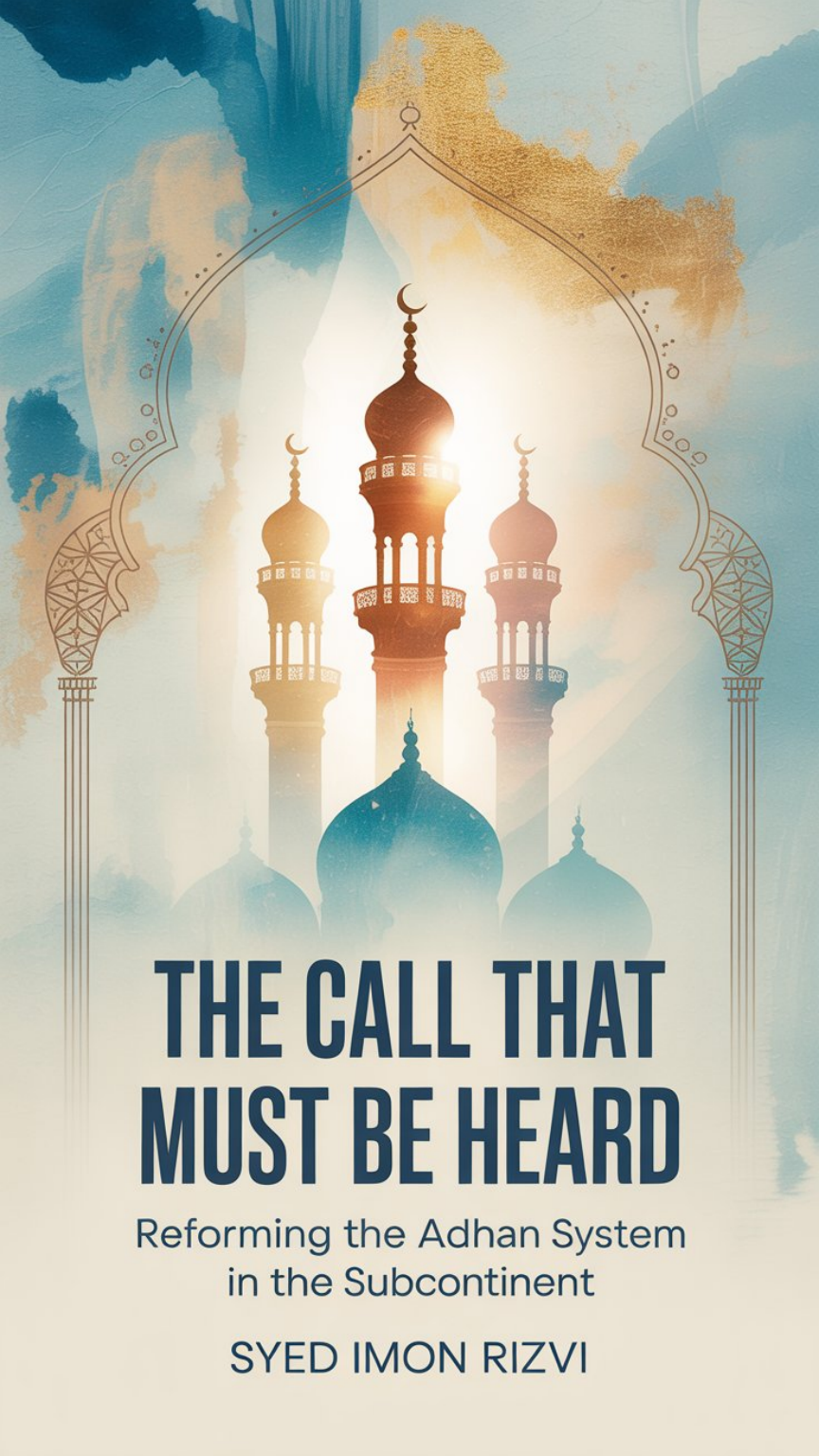




THE CALL THAT MUST BE HEARD

Reforming the Adhan System
in the Subcontinent

SYED IMON RIZVI

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in the Subcontinent*

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Introduction: The Beauty and Purpose of *Adhan*

Adhan is not just a call; it is a proclamation of *Tawhīd*, a spiritual invitation to connect with Allah five times a day. It serves as both a religious symbol and a communal unifier. The early Muslims used it as a powerful reminder of the Creator's presence and the unity of the Ummah.

But sadly, in many parts of the subcontinent — Pakistan, India, Bangladesh, and beyond — the Adhan has slowly lost its dignity and clarity, not because of any

fault in Islam, but due to our own cultural and administrative issues.

Current Challenges in Subcontinent Adhan Practice

1 Overlapping Multiple

Adhans: Confusion and Noise

- In every locality, dozens of mosques give Adhan at the same time.
- Instead of one beautiful unified call, people hear overlapping, disorganized sounds.
- In urban areas like Karachi, Lahore, Islamabad, and

Peshawar, sometimes the chaos is so great that one cannot hear even a single complete Adhan properly.

2 Lack of Proper Tilawah and Tajwīd

- The reciters often lack proper training in Arabic pronunciation and Tajwīd rules.
- Many mu'adhdhins (Adhan reciters) unintentionally distort words and meanings.
- Poor quality loudspeakers and echoing systems worsen the problem.

3 Domination by Elderly

Individuals

- A common problem is that ***elders monopolize*** the responsibility.
- Even when they lack proper ***voice quality, breathing capacity, or Tajwīd expertise***, they refuse to hand it over to younger, more capable individuals.
- This creates **frustration** among youth and deprives them of training and involvement.

4 The Culture of "Bossy Elders"

- In subcontinental households, the ***elderly often exercise*** absolute control over religious duties.
- Youth are ***discouraged***, sometimes humiliated, when they try to participate.
- The fear of “***disrespecting elders***” prevents constructive discussions.

5 Lack of Institutional

System and Training

- Most mosques lack any formal system to train *mu'adhdhins*.
- No *evaluation criteria* for voice quality, Tajwīd, or consistency.
- The position of mu'adhdhin is sometimes treated as an informal, unregulated responsibility.

6 Technological Negligence

- Unlike some advanced Muslim countries (e.g. Turkey, Malaysia, UAE, Iran), the subcontinent has not yet adopted a ***centralized, synchronized Adhan system***.
- Use of FM radios, satellite systems, or national broadcast timings could solve many issues.

The Vision: A Unified and Harmonized Adhan System

We need to shift from disorder to order, from tradition-bound chaos to *organized beauty* — without disrespecting our elders, but reforming the system for everyone's benefit.

Proposed *Model*

Stage 1: National Unified Adhan Broadcast

- Government-run TV, radio, and mobile apps issue Adhan at exact prescribed times.
- Muftis and scholars should supervise time calculations to ensure accuracy.
- This becomes the primary reference point for prayer timings.

Stage 2: Mosque-Level

Secondary Adhan

- Each mosque may give one Adhan inside mosque shortly before actual congregational Salah begins as it happens in different countries.
- This allows for some local flexibility while maintaining unity.

Stage 3: Formal Mu'adhdhin Training Programs

- Nationwide certification programs for mu'adhdhins.
- Standardized training in Tajwīd, voice modulation, and microphone handling.

Stage 4: Youth Involvement & Empowerment

- Encourage youth to participate.
- Elders should mentor youth instead of dominating them.
- The role of mu'adhdhin becomes an honorable and skill-based responsibility.

Benefits of Reform

- **Clear, unified *Adhan*** heard by all.
- Better ***pronunciation*** preserving the sanctity of the message.
- Youth engagement leading to continuity of ***quality recitation***.
- Respect for both religious beauty and modern city life challenges.

- Reduction of sound pollution complaints from non-Muslim neighbors.

Real-Life Models Already in Practice

- **Makkah and Madinah:** One unified Adhan system followed across the entire city.
- **Turkey:** State-controlled Adhan broadcast system with professional reciters.
- **Malaysia:** Synchronized Adhan broadcast via television, radio, and mobile networks.
- **Iran:** State-managed Synchronized Adhan

broadcast via television, radio,
and mobile networks.

The Way Forward: Our Collective Responsibility

- Scholars, government officials, mosque committees, parents, teachers, and youth must come together.
- Begin public discussions on television, social media, and community forums.
- Make this an issue of improvement, not personal egos or emotional sensitivities.

Final Words: Adhan Deserves Excellence

The Adhan is a symbol of Islam's dignity and order. As a society that claims love for Islam, we must honor it with proper organization, beauty, and discipline. It's not too late to bring reform, but it requires courage, wisdom, and collective will.

May **Allah** grant us the ability to reform ourselves and honor His **Deen** with sincerity.